

VOCABULARY BUILDER

Leadership: What Makes a Great Leader? – Key Words • Week 6 • Level B

The words and phrases below appear in the article *Leadership: What Makes a Great Leader?*. Study the table carefully — these are core Level B leadership and management terms that appear regularly in academic, business, and professional contexts. Then complete the gap-fill exercise in Part 2.

PART 1 – VOCABULARY TABLE

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
transformational leadership	a leadership approach that motivates people by inspiring a shared vision and developing their potential	<i>Under transformational leadership, employees are motivated by purpose rather than just pay or promotion.</i>
transactional leadership	a leadership style based on reward and punishment, focused on performance targets and compliance	<i>Transactional leadership can be effective for managing routine tasks, but rarely inspires deep loyalty.</i>
emotional intelligence	the ability to recognise, understand, and manage one's own emotions and those of others	<i>Research shows that emotional intelligence is a stronger predictor of leadership success than IQ alone.</i>
empathy	the ability to understand and share the feelings and perspectives of other people	<i>Leaders with genuine empathy retain their best employees far longer than those who lack it.</i>
integrity	the quality of being honest and having strong moral principles, even when it is inconvenient	<i>Without integrity, a leader may achieve short-term results but will eventually lose the trust of their team.</i>
visionary	having the ability to imagine and plan for a compelling and ambitious future	<i>A visionary leader communicates a clear picture of where the organisation is heading and why it matters.</i>
accountability	the obligation to accept responsibility for one's decisions and their consequences	<i>True accountability means owning failures as well as successes — not deflecting blame onto others.</i>
decisive	having the ability to make clear and firm decisions quickly, especially under pressure	<i>In a crisis, a decisive leader provides clarity and direction when others are uncertain.</i>
authoritarian	exercising strict control and expecting total obedience, without encouraging input from others	<i>An authoritarian approach may produce rapid compliance but often generates long-term resentment.</i>
delegation	the process of assigning tasks and responsibilities to other people in a team	<i>Effective delegation requires trusting your team and giving them the authority to make decisions.</i>

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
micromanagement	excessive control over every detail of a team's work, without trusting people to perform independently	<i>Micromanagement signals a lack of trust and consistently drives talented employees to resign.</i>
psychological safety	a shared belief in a team that it is safe to speak up, take risks, and make mistakes without punishment	<i>Teams with high psychological safety are significantly more innovative and more willing to admit errors.</i>
resilience	the ability to recover quickly from setbacks, adapt to challenges, and keep moving forward	<i>A resilient leader does not collapse under pressure — they model calmness and clarity for their team.</i>
succession planning	the process of identifying and developing future leaders to ensure the organisation continues effectively	<i>Companies that neglect succession planning often face serious instability when a key leader departs.</i>
authentic leadership	a leadership style in which the leader acts in accordance with their own values and is transparent about their limitations	<i>Authentic leadership builds deep trust because people can see that the leader is consistent and genuine.</i>
consensus	a general agreement reached by a group after discussion, in which most members are satisfied	<i>Effective leaders know when to seek consensus and when to make a unilateral decision and move forward.</i>
charisma	a compelling personal charm and attractiveness that inspires enthusiasm and loyalty in others	<i>Charisma can be a powerful leadership asset, but it is no substitute for substance and integrity.</i>
strategic thinking	the ability to analyse complex situations and plan long-term actions that achieve organisational goals	<i>Strategic thinking requires looking beyond immediate pressures to focus on where the organisation needs to be.</i>
ethical leadership	leadership that is guided by values and a commitment to doing what is right, not just what is profitable	<i>Ethical leadership creates organisations that can be trusted by customers, employees, and the wider public.</i>
legacy	the lasting impact that a leader leaves behind after they have finished their role	<i>A leader's true legacy is not their personal achievements but the strength they leave in the people around them.</i>

PART 2 – GAP-FILL EXERCISE

Complete the sentences using the correct word or phrase from the word bank below. You may need to change the form of the word. Most sentences require more than one answer.

WORD BANK

transformational leadership	transactional leadership	emotional intelligence	empathy
integrity	visionary	accountability	decisive
authoritarian	delegation	micromanagement	psychological safety
resilience	succession planning	authentic leadership	consensus
charisma	strategic thinking	ethical leadership	legacy

1	_____ operates on clear reward and punishment systems, while _____ seeks to change how people think — inspiring them through a shared vision and developing their potential.
2	_____ — particularly _____ — is consistently identified as the quality that most distinguishes outstanding leaders from merely competent ones.
3	A leader with genuine _____ understands how decisions affect their team, creates _____ in which people feel safe to take risks, and builds lasting _____ in the organisation.
4	Without _____, even the most _____ leader will eventually lose their team's trust — people need to know their leader is honest, not just impressive.
5	The most damaging form of _____ leadership is _____ — the inability to trust your team, which communicates a fundamental lack of confidence and drives talented people to resign.
6	A truly _____ leader acts in accordance with their own values and is transparent about their limitations — there is no gap between who they appear to be and who they actually are.
7	The most admired leaders in history understood that _____ — the lasting impact they leave behind — depends not on personal achievement but on _____ and the strength they built in others.
8	Effective _____ requires more than a good idea — it means looking beyond immediate pressures and planning for where the organisation needs to be in five or ten years' time.
9	When Nadella took over Microsoft, he replaced a culture of competition with one of learning — modelling the _____ and _____ he wanted to see across the entire organisation.
10	True _____ means owning failures as well as successes — a leader who deflects blame and never admits mistakes destroys the team's trust far faster than any single error would.
11	Many leaders with natural _____ rely too heavily on personal charm and fail to build the systems and talent pipelines that the organisation needs when they eventually leave.
12	Neglecting _____ is one of the most common failures of otherwise effective leaders — an organisation that cannot function without one person has a serious structural weakness.
13	The best leaders know when to seek _____ from their team and when to be _____ — gathering input takes time, but acting without it on complex issues often makes things worse.

14	Effective _____ — giving tasks and authority to others — frees the leader to focus on strategy while developing the team's capability and confidence at the same time.
15	_____ is not about avoiding difficult decisions — it is about making those decisions in ways that are guided by values, transparent to all _____, and designed to build lasting trust.

Write your answers here:

1. _____	2. _____	3. _____
4. _____	5. _____	6. _____
7. _____	8. _____	9. _____
10. _____	11. _____	12. _____
13. _____	14. _____	15. _____